

COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING, UIC



CS 377 Ethical Issues in Computing (3 Credit Hours)

“Evil comes from a failure to think” —Hannah Arendt

Spring 2026

Instructor & Course Details

Instructor	Jack Bandy, Ph.D.	Class Meeting	Monday and Wednesday
Email	jxb@uic.edu		CDRLC 2411
Office	CDRLC 3454	Office Hours	Monday and Wednesday 10am–11:30am CDRLC 3454 Please schedule here
TA	Abhijith Sreenivasan	Section	12:30pm Section
Email	asree5@uic.edu		
TA	Elda Shatro	Section	2:00pm Section
Email	eshatr2@uic.edu		

Course Site

[Canvas course](#) — Students are expected to log in to Canvas regularly to learn about any developments related to the course, upload assignments, and communicate with classmates.

Course Information

Catalog Course Description

Communication skills for computing professionals: presentation organization, visual aides, delivery techniques, argument support. Ethical and societal issues in computing: privacy, intellectual property and ownership, crime. **Prerequisite:** Credit or concurrent registration in CS 251.

Dr. Bandy's Course Description

What does it mean for Computer Scientists to be socially responsible? Billions of people interact with computational systems every day for communication, amusement, work, and more. Although many interactions appear to happen seamlessly, even the most mundane human-computer interaction often has ethical implications related to privacy, climate, power, inequality, public health, and more. To explore these ethical implications, this course will survey classical perspectives of ethics (i.e. Deontological Ethics, Utilitarian Ethics, Virtue Ethics, Care Ethics) and practice using them to interpret real-world situations involving humans and computers. Students will engage with recent

scholarship about ethical issues in algorithmic decision-making, data management, user interface design, software engineering, search engines, algorithmic media feeds, large language models, and chatbots, to name some examples. Class sessions will promote active engagement through peer teaching, small group discussions, games, and more.

Course Goals and Learning Outcomes

- Develop an understanding of (personal and) professional responsibilities related to ethical, legal, security, and social issues in computing
- Practice describing current events in computing through classical ethical perspectives (i.e. Deontological Ethics, Utilitarian Ethics, Virtue Ethics, Care Ethics)
- Identify recurring ethical challenges in computer science
- Develop a growth mindset for continuing (personal and) professional development, especially for effective decision-making and communication with different audiences

Course requirement status: CS 377 is [required](#) for a BS in Computer Science at UIC

Topics overview: Classical ethical theories (Virtue, Deontological, Utilitarian, Care Ethics); algorithmic feeds and content moderation; privacy and contextual integrity; inequality and algorithmic fairness; general cybersecurity; AI and large language models; intellectual property; environmental costs of computing.

Required and Recommended Course Materials

Copies of core readings will be provided to you via printed copies, web archives, and/or PDFs. Although there are no required books for this course, we will draw quite a bit from the following textbook:

- *Computing and Technology Ethics: Engaging through Science Fiction* by Emanuelle Burton, Judy Goldsmith, Nicholas Mattei, Cory Siler, and Sara-Jo Swiatek

Students will also make their own selections of different research papers, case studies, books, and other materials to present and discuss in class.

Growth Mindset

Course materials and assignments can be complex and challenging, but they are crucial to your intellectual and personal growth and development. There are times you may need extra help. Students who attend class consistently, complete all assignments, thoughtfully engage with feedback on work, develop good study strategies, visit the tutoring center, and contact faculty when struggling can develop a thorough understanding of the course material and ultimately succeed in the course.

Required Technology

The only technology you need is a web browser, from which you can access Canvas, course materials, and the Github repository for the class.

Respect for Copyright

Please protect the copyright integrity of course materials. Particularly when it comes to materials in canvas, do not upload to third-party websites or share with anyone not enrolled in our course.

Course Policies & Classroom Expectations

Grading Policy and Point Breakdown

This class aims to use principles of student-centered teaching, also referred to as “non-directive teaching,” which de-emphasizes quantitative grading. This style focuses on open-ended dialogue, project-based learning, and student curiosity, rather than regurgitation and examinations. Still, in order to provide a final letter grade at the end of the class, I will use the following combination of exercises:

Out-of-class Exercises	20%
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Food in your feed
Online account biopsy
Online account scrap doll
Speculative fiction
Fairness definition
Personal ethical commitment

Read a Book	20%
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Book selection
2-page book report or un-essay
Peer instruction / book presentation
Actually reading the book

In-class Group Exercises	20%
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Expect about one per week

Pre-Class Reflections	20%
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Expect about one per week

Attendance, Participation, Civility	20%
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You can expect the following correspondence between your percentage grade in the course and your final letter grade, and the “equivalent” description from the registrar.

F	D	C	B	A
59% or below	60–69%	70–79%	80–89%	90–100%
Failure	Poor but passing	Average	Good	Excellent

Tests

There will be no tests or examinations in this class. I agree with Carl Rogers¹ that life itself offers enough examinations, and I hope the resources from this class help you meet life's tests with more confidence and satisfaction. See above for details regarding your final grade in the class.

Policy for Missed or Late Work

All due dates are listed in Canvas. For out-of-class exercises and pre-class reflections, late submissions may not be accepted after one week past the due date. For in-class group exercises, if you miss class that day, I will provide materials to make up the exercise.

If you anticipate difficulty meeting a deadline, please reach out *before* the due date — I am generally more flexible when contacted in advance.

Attendance and Participation Policy

Showing up makes a big difference! As an instructor, I put a lot of effort into planning classes that are meaningful, engaging, and valuable for your learning. As a student enrolled in this course, I expect that you put a similar effort into attending class meetings, arriving on time, and participating.

If you need to miss class due to illness, personal emergencies, and/or other unexpected situations, please notify the instructor as soon as possible so it can be recorded as an excused absence.

I will keep attendance on paper via roll call this semester and note any absences in Canvas. If you miss more than 50% of class sessions, you will automatically fail the course. You are allowed three “free” absences without penalty, which do not have to be explicitly excused. If you miss a fourth class without notifying the instructor, you will be contacted by the instructor.

The spring semester at UIC is fifteen weeks long (not including spring vacation), and we meet Mondays and Wednesdays. With no class on Martin Luther King Jr. Day (Monday, January 19th), we will have 29 total class periods.

Academic Integrity

As a student and member of the UIC community, you are expected to adhere to the Community Standards of academic integrity, accountability, and respect. Please review the UIC Student Disciplinary Policy for additional information; the UIC community standards for academic integrity are available at: <https://dos.uic.edu/community-standards/>

More concretely, my job and my goal in this course is to help you as you learn skills and knowledge that will be valuable to you in your future courses, your career, and other areas of your life. In line with UIC's mission to provide “an environment in which research, learning, and scholarship can flourish and in which all endeavors are guided by academic and professional integrity,” **the work you turn in for this class must be your own work.**

This does not mean that you need to complete all work in a bunker. Rather, you are encouraged to discuss your ideas with friends and classmates, and to explore related work (i.e. academic papers, blogs, video essays, forums, etc.). An important part of scholarship is standing on the shoulders of

¹On *Becoming a Person*, Chapter 14

giants,² (after all, we are in the City of the Big Shoulders³) and acknowledging whose shoulders we stand upon. In other words, **cite your sources!**

Please ask the instructor if you need clarity about academic integrity for specific exercises. When in doubt, it is always better to check with the instructor before proceeding.

I will reach out to you personally before submitting a report of academic misconduct.

Visitors

This class may welcome visitors (i.e. prospective students, guest speakers, etc.) during the semester. When possible, students will be notified in advance of guest attendance.

Email Expectations

Students are responsible for all information instructors send to your UIC email and Canvas accounts. Faculty messages should be regularly monitored and read in a timely fashion.

While I do not closely monitor my email on Saturdays and Sundays, during the week, I generally respond to emails within 24 hours.

Course Schedule

Week	Date(s)	Topic(s) / In-Class Activities	Readings / Work Due
1	1/12–1/14	Warm-up activity; introduction to Virtue Ethics	
2	1/19–1/21	MLK Day (no class); introduction to Deontological Ethics	Virtue Ethics Reflection (1/20)
3	1/26–1/28	Introduction to Utilitarian Ethics and trolley problems; introduction to Care Ethics	Deontological Ethics Reflection (1/25); Utilitarian Ethics Reflection (1/27)
4	2/2–2/4	Ethical theory review and case studies; Ethics in Algorithmic Feeds	Care Ethics Reflection (2/1); Select a Book (2/1); Food in your Feed (2/3); Ranking Exercise (2/4)
5	2/9–2/11	Algorithmic feeds; introduction to Privacy and contextual integrity	Privacy Policy Exercise (2/11)

(continued)

²Ironically, while this phrase is often attributed to Isaac Newton in a letter from 1676, it was first recorded in John of Salisbury's book *Metalogicon* from 1159. I learned this from a blog post on BookBrowse.com

³Sandburg, Carl. "Chicago." *Poetry* (March 1914).

Week	Date(s)	Topic(s) / In-Class Activities	Readings / Work Due
6	2/16-2/18	Privacy and short story analysis; Dr. Bandy at SIGCSE (activity TBA)	Here-and-Now Reflection (2/15); Online Account Biopsy (2/20)
7	2/23-2/25	Inequality, Justice, and algorithmic fairness	Message in a Bottle Reflection (2/22); Online Account Scrap Doll (2/24)
8	3/2-3/4	Cybersecurity; medical and health technologies in AI	Speculative Fiction (3/3)
9	3/9-3/11	LLM ethical challenges	
10	3/16-3/18	Intellectual property	Fairness Definitions (3/17)
11	3/23-3/25	<i>Spring Vacation — No Classes</i>	
12	3/30-4/1	Environmental computing impact; book presentations begin	
13	4/6-4/8	Book presentations	
14	4/13-4/15	Book presentations	
15	4/20-4/22	Book presentations	Personal Ethics Commitments (4/21)
16	4/27-4/29	Synthesis and conclusions	Book Report/Un-essay, Presentation, & “Actually Read” (all 5/1)

Disclaimer

This syllabus is intended to give the student guidance on what may be covered during the semester and will be followed as closely as possible. However, the instructor might alter this syllabus as course needs arise. I will communicate such changes in advance through in-class announcements and in writing via Canvas and/or email.

Accommodations

Disability Accommodation Procedures

UIC is committed to full inclusion and participation of people with disabilities in all aspects of university life. If you face or anticipate disability-related barriers while at UIC, please connect with

the Disability Resource Center (DRC) at <https://drc.uic.edu>, via email at drc@uic.edu, or call (312) 413-2183 to create a plan for reasonable accommodations. To receive accommodations, you will need to disclose the disability to the DRC, complete an interactive registration process with the DRC, and provide me with a Letter of Accommodation (LOA). Upon receipt of an LOA, I will gladly work with you and the DRC to implement approved accommodations.

Religious Accommodations

Following campus policy, if you wish to observe religious holidays, you must notify me by the tenth day of the semester. If the religious holiday is observed on or before the tenth day of the semester, you must notify me at least five days before you will be absent. Please submit this form by email with the subject heading: "YOUR NAME: Requesting Religious Accommodation."

Classroom Environment

Inclusive Community

UIC values diversity and inclusion. Regardless of age, disability, ethnicity, race, gender, gender identity, sexual orientation, socioeconomic status, geographic background, religion, political ideology, language, or culture, we expect all members of this class to contribute to a respectful, welcoming, and inclusive environment for every other member of our class. If aspects of this course result in barriers to your inclusion, engagement, accurate assessment, or achievement, please notify me as soon as possible.

Name and Pronoun Use

If your name does not match the name on my class roster, please let me know as soon as possible. My pronouns are he/him, and I welcome your pronouns if you would like to share them with me. For more information about pronouns, see: <https://www.mypronouns.org/what-and-why>.

Guidelines for Participation and Classroom Conduct

Active participation is one of the most important ways you will learn in this course. I am very aware that participation looks a little different for everyone, and will evaluate your participation accordingly. Still, in general, an engaged student will:

- come to class prepared, for example, by having completed pre-class reflections
- contribute regularly to class activities and discussions
- stay on-task during class
- listen attentively to peers (no side conversations or unnecessary disruptions)
- have an open mind and seek to understand (not judge and make assumptions)
- be gracious and open to change in their ideas, arguments, and positions
- assume goodwill in all interactions, even in disagreement
- complete their work in a timely manner
- reach out to the instructor if they start to fall behind

Content Notices

Our classroom provides an open space for a civil exchange of ideas which will intentionally include a variety of perspectives and positions. Some readings and other content may expose you to ideas, subjects, or views that may challenge you, cause you discomfort, or recall past negative experiences or traumas. I intend to discuss all subjects with dignity and humanity. If you would like me to be aware of a specific topic of concern, please email or visit me during office hours.

Resources: Academic Success, Wellness, and Safety

Student Wellbeing

As a student at UIC, I hope you have come to enjoy the learning process and the life of the mind, and I hope you enjoy this particular course. I also understand that life as a college student can sometimes become distressing and overwhelming, which can make it difficult to engage in class.

So, to help you succeed in this course (and in life), I encourage you to proactively care for your body and mind. If you are struggling or anticipate any trouble attending class or turning in assignments on time, please let me know as early as possible and I will do whatever I can to help you prioritize your wellbeing.

Below are some of the many support services and resources available to all UIC students:

- Current Student Resources – a one-stop shop for links to resources in the following categories: General, Academic, Student Support, Student Life, Technology, Health and Safety, and Getting Around Campus
- UIC Tutoring Resources
- UIC College of Engineering Tutoring Program
- The First-at-LAS academic success program for first-generation students
- Programs and initiatives supporting the UIC undergraduate experience and academic programs through the Student Success Initiative
- If you are experiencing personal hardships (e.g. personal and family emergencies, academics, interpersonal conflicts, personal safety, physical and mental health concerns, food or housing insecurity) and need resources and assistance, please reach out to the Student Assistance division
- Student Guide for Information Technology – a comprehensive resource for UIC students describing the most commonly used IT services and tools supporting your success
- Navigating Health Resources at UIC – explore the many resources that are on campus to support students' health and wellbeing and learn about how you can access them.

Importantly, if you are in immediate distress, please know the UIC Counseling Center has crisis intervention services available 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. You can walk into the Counseling Center during business hours to request to talk to a crisis counselor, or you can call the Counseling Center main line at (312)~996-3490. If you are calling outside of business hours, select “2” during the automated greeting to be connected to a crisis counselor. You can find additional mental health resources and services on the Counseling Center Website and the Student’s Guide to Accessing Behavioral Health Services at UIC.

For immediate crisis support outside of UIC, call or text “9-8-8” any time, 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. Dialing 988 will connect you to a trained crisis professional. 988 offers services in Spanish, American Sign Language, and over 240 languages through tele-interpretation services. The 988

website has an online chat feature, too.

We all need the help and the support of our UIC community. Please visit my office hours for course consultation and other academic or research topics. For additional assistance, please contact your assigned college advisor and visit the support services available to all UIC students.

Academic Success

- Equity and Inclusion in Engineering Program
- UIC Library and UIC Library Research Guides
- Offices supporting the UIC undergraduate experience and academic programs

Wellness

- Access U&I Care Program for assistance with personal hardships
- Campus Advocacy Network (Title IX): TitleIX@uic.edu and <http://can.uic.edu/>

Safety

- UIC Safe App (please download for your safety)
- UIC Safety Tips and Resources
- Night Ride
- Emergency: Dial 5-5555 from a campus phone, or (312) 355-5555 from a cell phone

The following are mostly boilerplate blurbs from our Academic Center for Excellence (ACE).⁴

Support for Parenting Students: UIC supports parenting students by providing affordable, high-quality childcare for infants, toddlers, and young children, along with a comprehensive wraparound care system, study-play areas across campus, accessible lactation rooms, year-round family events, and more. For more information, contact Melinda Young (mmcghe2@uic.edu) or visit the [Little Sparks website](#).

The Writing Center offers friendly and supportive tutors who can help you with reading and writing in any of your courses, not just English. Tutors are ready to help with other writing as well, such as job applications, personal statements, and resumes. The tutor and you will work together to decide how to improve your writing. If you have not started your assignment, that is OK. A tutor can help you brainstorm or make an outline. Tutors understand that you might be using the Writing Center for the first time. They are ready to guide you through your first session. You can choose to work with a tutor in person or in real time over the internet using video, audio, or chat and a whiteboard. For more information and to schedule an appointment, visit the Writing Center website.

The Math and Science Learning Center, located in the Science and Engineering South Building (SES) at 845 W. Taylor St. 3rd Floor, Room 247, is a meeting place for students in Math, Biological Sciences, Chemistry, Earth and Environmental Sciences, and Physics. At the MSLC, students can meet with graduate teaching assistants for tutoring in 100-level courses, attend informal group study sessions with other students, or meet up with friends to attend one of the workshops, seminars, or other activities sponsored by the MSLC during the semester. Visit the MSLC website, call 312-355-4900, or email at mslc@uic.edu.

The Academic Center for Excellence (ACE) can help if you feel you need more individualized

⁴<https://teaching.uic.edu/cate-teaching-guides/syllabus-course-design/syllabus/>

instruction in reading and/or writing, study skills, time management, etc. Please call (312)~413-0031 or visit the Academic Center for Excellence (ACE) website for more information.

Emergency response guides can be found at the Office of Preparedness and Response. Please review and acquaint yourself with the guide and recommendations for various emergency situations.

Student Health Services are available if you get sick during the semester. The Family Medicine Center is committed to providing high-quality, student centered care and services. It has attending physicians, residents, and nurse practitioners on staff to provide the full range of primary health care services. The Family Medicine Center also offers a limited set of health services at no additional cost to students who pay the Student Health Service Fee (SHSF). Services include caring for an acute or urgent illness (e.g., cold, strep throat, asthma attack, flu) or an injury. More information can be found on the Family Medicine Center's Student Health webpage.

Lastly, since there is still space left on page ten, here is a picture of Hannah Arendt. She said that "evil comes from a failure to think." If we are successful in this class, we will do some real thinking.



Hannah Arendt, photographed on New Year's Day, 1944.
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